

ALL-IN-WONDERS!

If your business is growing fast, you'll soon need a multi-functional device that can keep up with the needs of your organisation—here's what you need to decide on one

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Office needs that have to do with paper—printing, scanning, fax printouts, and copying—have solutions primarily in the form of inkjet and laser devices. The other classification is standalone devices vs. MFDs. The latter is not much of a dilemma any more, really: MFDs are here to stay, and with good reason. But in regards to the former—inkjet or laser—you might ask: why a laser MFD test now, when we did an inkjet test two months ago?

It's simple. Inkjet MFDs are good for the SoHo consumer. They are great if your work requires colour prints such as photographs, and if you are on a tight budget. Now as your business grows, your needs grow too, and when your regular daily workload involves high-volume, high-speed printing—and if colour prints are not a daily affair—you need a faster and more cost-effective solution than inkjet MFDs. That's where the lasers come in. These are more expensive than inkjets, but the initial cost is recovered quickly—within a few months of printing.

To give you a good feel for what the market has to offer, in fact, to help you with a purchase decision, we rounded up quite a few laser MFDs and tested them to see if they perform as they promise. (You must go beyond the advertisements!) We reviewed four laser MFDs from Brother, three from Canon, five from HP, and one each from Lexmark and Panasonic.

The MFDs we've tested here range from the very basic to the heavy-duty, and we've also included copier-based MFDs that cost less than Rs 50,000.

From Brother, we have the DCP-7010, MFC-7320, MFC-8460N and MFC-8860DN. We have the Canon MF4122 and MF4150, along with the Lexmark X342n and Panasonic KX-FLB802CX. From the HP stables, we have the M1005 MFP, 3052 All-in-One, 3055 All-in-One, 3390 All-in-One, and the 3392 All-in-One—all of them under HP's LaserJet range of products.

We categorised the MFDs into three classes for your convenience:

Budget MFDs—priced up to Rs 16,000: These are for businesses just starting up and those that cannot afford to put in too much capital into a laser device, yet want a solution that is faster and more cost-effective than an inkjet machine. Small establishments would rather have a device that can do it all—print, scan and copy—than standalone devices, because of limited resources and office space. The MFDs in this category are the Brother DCP-7010, HP LaserJet M1005 MFP, and the Panasonic KX-FLB802CX.

SoHo MFDs—priced between Rs 16,001 and Rs 30,000: The products in this category are for businesses at the SoHo (Small Office Home Office) stage. Standalone fax functionality assumes some importance here. The Brother MFC-7420, Canon imageCLASS MF4122 and MF4150, HP LaserJet 3052 All-in-One and 3055 All-in-One, and the Lexmark X342n fall in this bracket.

SMB MFDs—priced between Rs 30,001 and Rs 50,000: Look in this category if you are a small or medium business (SMB) that requires very high-volume printing, speed, and also machines that can handle heavy workloads while having the capability of being networked. This bracket is populated by the Brother MFC-8460N and MFC-8860DN, and the HP LaserJet 3390 All-in-One and 3392 All-in-One.

With all the above in mind, read on to find out which products delivered and which didn't, which seem unlikely purchases for you and which seem right.



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